Study Guide for PHIL 1301 – Final Exam

You will be asked to complete several essay-type questions on the final exam, some of which will be drawn from the earlier part of the course (covering Plato and Descartes) and some of which will be drawn from the latter part of the course (covering Hume, Marx, and Sartre). The following study questions are the pool from which the final exam questions will be drawn. Study them with care and you should pass the final exam without a problem!

Socrates & Plato:

Why does the *Euthyphro* focus on a discussion of piety?

Socrates expresses dissatisfaction (at 6c-d) with Euthyphro's first answer (given at 5d-e). Why? What's wrong with it? What more (if anything) do we learn about what kind of answer Socrates is looking for?

How could the sort of investigation Socrates suggests make any progress towards an answer when the questioner (Socrates) is ignorant and the respondent (Euthyphro) is now in confusion? Mustn't somebody know something in order for the inquiry to get off the ground or move in the right direction?

How does Socrates understand his philosophical career? What are his motivations for being a philosopher? What does he hope to achieve by his philosophical activities?

Why does Socrates think the Athenian people ought to value his philosophical activities? What (if anything) do they stand to gain from them?

Socrates says that the god has sent him to persuade the Athenians to care for the most important things. What are these important things? How, in Socrates's view, are the Athenians neglecting them? Why does Socrates think that these things are more important or valuable than the things the Athenians actually care for?

Beginning at 46b Socrates examines Crito's assumption that one ought to pay attention to what the majority of people believe. At 48a, he reaches the conclusion that Crito was mistaken about this. What is the argument for this conclusion?

In the *Crito* Socrates seems to be quite certain about very many things; in fact his certainty about a number of moral principles leads him to reject Crito's offer to arrange an escape. Is this consistent with the Socratic ignorance we've seen in both the *Apology* and *Euthyphro*?

Descartes:

Explain the relationship between intellect and will, according to Descartes, and how it is possible that we err.

Explain the distinction between formal and objective reality. What things have what kind of reality?

Explain and analyze the Cartesian Circle. Is Descartes guilty of circular reasoning?

Explain the distinction between primary and secondary qualities. How do we perceive them and what kind of knowledge do we have of them?

What stops the doubt of the First Meditation? What kind of reasoning supports the *cogito*?

What does the Wax Argument show? What is it meant to show? Does it succeed?

Analyze and evaluate the two proofs of God's existence. How are they different? Is one more convincing than the other? Why did Descartes think he needed two proofs? Do they do different work for him?

How do mind and body interact? How does the body affect the mind? And how does the mind affect the body?

Hume:

Into what two classes does Hume divide perceptions? How does he distinguish them?

To what does the creative power of the mind amount?

How should we ascertain the meaning of a philosophical term?

What three principles of association does Hume discover?

Into what two kinds does Hume divide "the objects of reason or inquiry"? Include examples.

How is knowledge of cause-effect relations attainable? Are any laws of nature knowable *a priori*? Explain.

Can it be demonstrated (i.e., by reasoning *a priori*) that because (1) all X's have in the past been followed by Y's, then (2) X's in the future will be followed by Y's?

Why is it circular to argue in a probabilistic manner that the future will be like the past?

Hegel & Marx:

What are the three methods of dealing with history?

How are these three methods *distinguished from one another*? In other words, identify the basic "elements" of each method and contrast them with one another—in this section that will be easiest done with the first two methods.

What shouldn't we expect from a *philosophical* approach to history? What is the basic approach of *philosophical* history?

Why and how do Marx and Engels praise capitalism in the first chapter of the *Manifesto*?

What do Marx and Engels mean by abolition of private property and how do they answer the various refutations of this program?

How many of the points in the 10-point program have been achieved by the working class in this country? If some points *have* been achieved under capitalism, what does this fact tell you about the *Communist Manifesto*? Why is it that some have been at least partially achieved, and yet some seem as far away as ever?

How would you describe the concept of Freedom put forward in the second chapter of the *Manifesto*?

What does the Manifesto tell us about the how the proletariat changes as capitalism develops?

Sartre:

What are the two main kinds of existentialist? To which does Sartre belong? What, according to Sartre, do all existentialists believe in common?

What did 18th century atheism discard? What did it keep to which Sartre objects?

What does it mean to say that existence precedes essence? On what basis does Sartre hold that there is no human nature (essence)?

What does Sartre mean by "In choosing for himself, he chooses for all men"?

Why does the existentialist find it embarrassing that "God does not exist"? If God did exist, would that change anything, according to Sartre?

Why does Sartre say that man is “condemned to be free”?

How does Sartre agree with Descartes? What does he find inadequate about Descartes' philosophy?

Who is a "self-deceiver" (a person of "bad faith")? How can Sartre judge such a person if all truth is a matter of human subjectivity?